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Being Curious @ IIMA

The Joy of Learning (Back to Campus edition)

**Vikas Surani**

Global Vice President – Growth | TEDx Speaker | IIMA



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Hello Curious Minds,

There's a particular feeling you get when you walk onto a campus after years of hustling over deadlines, quarterly reviews, and business cycles.

It's a mix of calm, energy, and a very real reminder that you're here to learn again — honestly, I wasn't ready for it... but yeah, it's refreshing too.

This first immersion at IIM Ahmedabad wasn't about "one week of classes." It was about rediscovering what learning feels like when you step out of your routine and into a space designed entirely for thinking, reflecting, and stretching your mind.

Here are the **learning moments** that stayed with me — not theories, not frameworks, but the *inferences* you only gather when you're in the room, listening, debating, and watching 120 professionals with over 2000 years of collective experience see the same problem very differently.

1. Learning hits differently when you're not distracted.

The very first instruction: **No phones on the table. Not even in your pocket.** And believe me — it felt good.

It was like removing “background noise” from a song you’ve heard a thousand times and suddenly realising how rich it actually sounds.

No notifications. No pings. No parallel mental tabs open.

Just a classroom, a case, a discussion, and people genuinely trying to decode a situation.

I had forgotten how much we absorb when we give a topic our full attention.

2. Diversity isn’t a slogan — it’s a learning accelerator.

Same case. Same professor. But every table had a different conclusion.

It reminded me of looking at a diamond under different lights — the stone is the same, but each angle reveals something new.

People from manufacturing, BFSI, tech, pharma, infra, retail... Everyone brought a lens I didn’t expect.

Half the learning came from the case; the other half came from how others interpreted it.

3. Good questions are more powerful than good answers.

Every session had that one moment — a curious question that shifted the entire conversation.

Sometimes it unlocked the case. Sometimes it exposed an assumption we didn’t even know we were carrying.

The right question can turn the direction of an entire room. In the daily rush of execution, we forget how powerful that is.

4. Leaders learn faster when they unlearn first.

We all walked in with years of experience, shortcuts, and mental models.

The discussions made it clear: some of those shortcuts help, and some quietly limit how far we can see.

Unlearning isn’t a grand moment of enlightenment. It’s those small “wait... that’s true” pauses.

5. Experience only becomes insight when shared.

People shared real stories — decisions, misses, dilemmas, pressure moments.

It felt like everyone emptied their backpacks on the table. Only then do

you see the common threads, the patterns, the insights.

Experience has value only when you take it out of your head and put it into the conversation.

6. Learning environments matter.

The long walks across campus. Conversations over tea. Late-night discussions at the hotel.

These weren't fillers — they were extensions of the classroom.

Sometimes learning doesn't happen in front of a projector; it happens on a quiet bench where a conversation suddenly clicks.

7. Joy is underrated in leadership learning.

Between roles, responsibilities, and expectations, the *joy* quietly fades.

This immersion brought it back — the simple joy of being curious, asking “why,” debating with energy, and walking out of a room feeling a little sharper than when you walked in.

It felt less like “executive education” and more like tuning an instrument that had gone slightly off-beat over time.

So, what's the real takeaway?

This wasn't a “module.”

Yes, It was a “back to school” moment

but more importantly, It was a reminder of something fundamental:

Learning isn't a spectator sport — it stays with you only when you're in the game.

And maybe that's why this journey matters.

Not because it adds a line to a profile.

But because it brings back something every leader needs —

Yes, its simple though not easy, the habit of learning with joy, not obligation.

Stay Curious, Vikas Surani

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**AMOL S. VYAWAHARE** • 1st
Manager - GMP and Compliance @ Abbott Healthcare Pvt Ltd | Ens...

2w ...

Wonderful work, Vikas! You have summarise our learning experience in best way. This brings back the essence of our shared IIM Ahmadabad experience — curiosity, collaboration, and continuous learning. Just subscribed. Keep sharing these insights; they genuinely add value to our collective journey.

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**Vikas Surani**  Author
Global Vice President – Growth | TEDx Speaker | IIMA

2w ...

AMOL S. VYAWAHARE Thanks, Amol — appreciate it. What makes the experience memorable is how each of us brings a different lens to the classroom. Glad the reflections connected with you, and thanks for subscribing. Looking forward to more shared learning moments ahead.

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**aprajita aditya**  • 1st
Senior Software Engineer

2w ...

Very well summarised 🙌🙌

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**Vikas Surani**  Author
Global Vice President – Growth | TEDx Speaker | IIMA

2w ...

**Ibrahim Kaizen**   • 1st
Leadership Performance Architect™ | I build high-trust, high-velocit...
aprajita aditya Thanks, Aprajita! Glad it resonated.

2w ...

There's a special kind of aliveness that only comes from being a student again.

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No titles, no posturing; just signal, questions, and growth.
Glad you're sharing the journey.

Like ·  1 | Reply · 1 reply

**Vikas Surani**  Author
Global Vice President – Growth | TEDx Speaker | IIMA

2w ...

Ibrahim Kaizen Beautifully said, Ibrahim. Stepping back into a classroom strips everything down to curiosity, questions, and real growth. It's been energising to experience that again.
Glad to share the journey — and always appreciate your perspective.

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**Zain Saeed Malik**  • 2nd
System Engineer | Beat Burnout by Building SYSTEMS for energy, fo...

2w ...

Great learning and enjoy it is powerful , its 2 in 1 package (learning + joy) **Vikas Surani**

Like ·  1 | Reply · 1 reply

**Vikas Surani**  Author
Global Vice President – Growth | TEDx Speaker | IIMA

2w ...

Zain Saeed Malik Thanks, Zain! Absolutely — when learning and joy come together, it hits differently. Glad this connected.

Like | Reply | 21 impressions

**Himathbai Khimani** • 1st

2w ...



Himatbhai Khimani
Process Safety Expert / Loss Prevention Professional / Technical Saf...

Excellent thoughts!
Keep sharpening skills and trying to match with present & future demand, always rewards!

Wishing you all the best **Vikas Surani**!

Like · 1 | Reply · 1 reply



Vikas Surani Author
Global Vice President – Growth | TEDx Speaker | IIMA

2w ...

Himatbhai Khimani Thank you, Himatbhai. Absolutely — staying sharp and aligned with the future is what keeps us moving forward. Appreciate your wishes and encouragement.



Being Curious

A weekly newsletter where I share quick insights, experiences, and lessons learned from my journey.



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